minister. The group also undertook several other social projects in Bihar. Appreciating their work, Yadav became a friend and well-wisher of the group. Irani said that if you engage in corrupt practices yourself, then you cannot expect the political leadership to be fair to you. He elaborated, 'We stuck to our policy of doing business the proper way and he [Yadav] understood that.'

Rarely does a business house follow the exacting ethical standards that the Tatas have. It is a tradition with the group, and it goes a long way back, says Y.H. Malegam. According to him, the group's philosophy is different. It does not 'take advantage of loopholes [to the disadvantage of the other party]; if there is any doubt, decide against yourself', is what they do. If anything, Ratan took this to another level. At the time of the conclusion of the Corus deal, Credit Suisse, the investment banking firm, set up avenues through which a loan was raised for the transaction. But the terms were onerous and soon after the conclusion of the deal, Tata Steel entered into an agreement with a consortium of banks to take over the loan on better terms.

But Credit Suisse wanted some of the payments for the actions that they had planned to take but had not yet taken. Koushik Chatterjee says that though the group could have built a case not to pay the services for the arrangements it had not yet made, Ratan advised the finance team headed by Chatterjee to 'do all the economics', but to do nothing that would give any one an opportunity to say that they were not paid what was due to them. It made the finance team take a liberal approach to the issue.

Valuing Trust

Just as Ratan expects people to trust him, he too easily trusts others. This, at times, made him a poor judge of character, said Irani. '[Ratan] sometimes has blind faith in the people who are close to him,' he felt.

Soonawala says that Ratan is very trusting and 'people took advantage of him'. Praveer Sinha comments, 'Over a period of time, he trusted a lot of people who did not stand by him. He should have used his discretion better.' Roger Pereira had also aired a similar view and opined that even JRD was quite chary of Ratan's choice of people.

But when Ratan is betrayed, he can be unrelenting in his efforts to correct the situation. While he can be extremely generous, understanding and believing of people, he is never kind to someone who deliberately violates